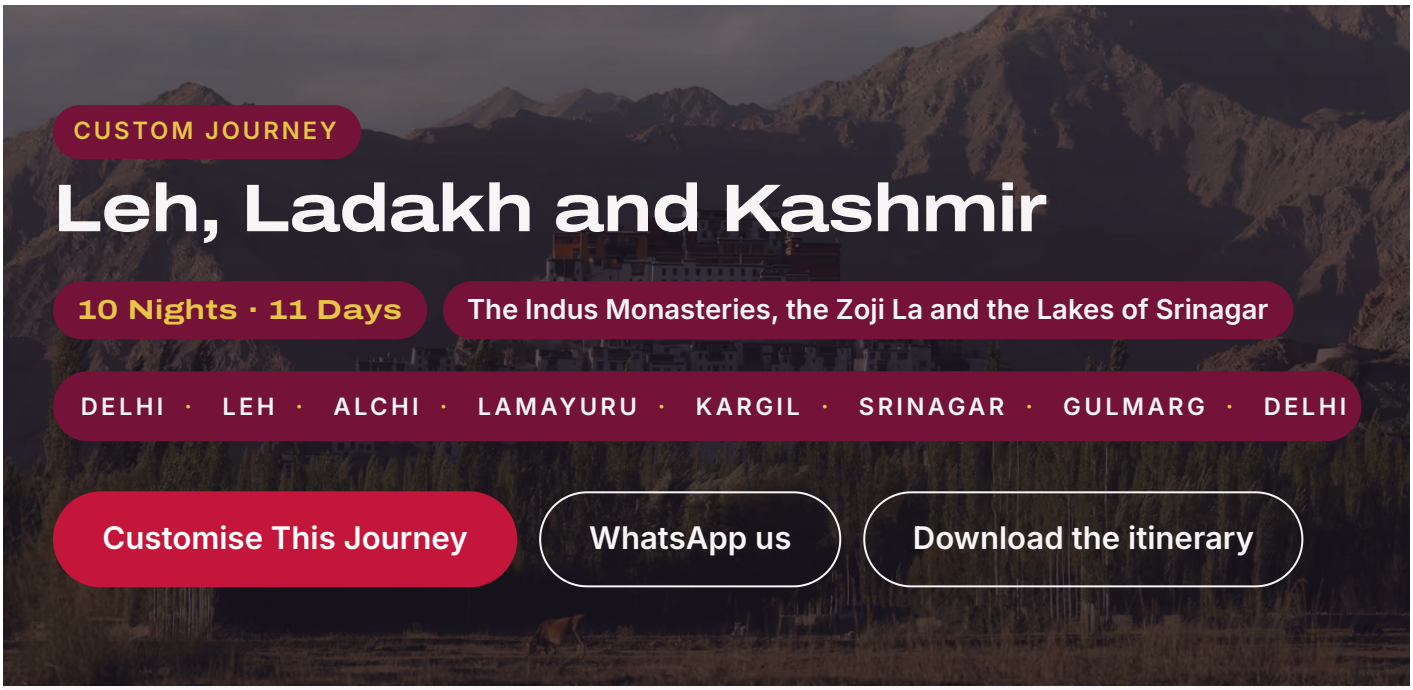
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DURATION
10 Nights · 11 Days

ROUTE
Delhi return

PACE
Moderate

BEST SEASON
June to September

IDEAL FOR
Couples, Solo

Ladakh is the least Indian-feeling part of India: a high cold desert in the rain shadow of the Himalaya, Tibetan Buddhist in its monasteries and its calendar, and reached by a flight that drops you at eleven and a half thousand feet with no warning. This journey does it properly. It gives the first day to acclimatising, the next three to the monasteries of the Indus valley (Shey, Thiksey, Hemis, Alchi, Lamayuru), and then does what most Ladakh itineraries do not: it drives out, west over the Zoji La, into Kashmir.

That second half is the reason for the route. Srinagar's lakes and Mughal gardens and the meadow at Gulmarg are the green answer to Ladakh's rock, and seeing both in one trip is the kind of contrast that stays with people. The road is open from June to September, which is when we run it; every flight, transfer and permit is handled, and the pace is set by the altitude rather than the schedule.

Journey Highlights

- **Fly** from Delhi into Leh, eleven and a half thousand feet up in the rain shadow of the Himalaya, and give the first day to doing nothing at all.
- **Visit** the great monasteries of the Indus valley: Shey's gilded Buddha, the fifteen-metre Maitreya at Thiksey, Hemis, Spituk and Phyang.
- **Stand** before the eleventh-century murals of Alchi, among the oldest surviving paintings in Ladakh, on the road to Lamayuru.
- **Cross** from Ladakh into Kashmir over the Zoji La, one of the highest passes on the road, with Kargil the overnight between.
- **Glide** across Dal Lake in a shikara at Srinagar, and walk the Mughal gardens: Nishat, Shalimar, Chashma Shahi and the Pari Mahal.
- **Spend** a day in the meadow of flowers at Gulmarg, with the gondola up towards Apharwat and the highest golf course in the world below it.

Itinerary at a Glance

DAY	DESTINATION	SIGNATURE EXPERIENCE
Day 01	**Delhi**	Arrival; Old and New Delhi
Day 02	**Delhi to Leh**	Fly to Leh; a full day of acclimatisation
Day 03	**Leh**	Leh Palace, the bazaar; Spituk and Phyang
Day 04	**Leh**	Shey, Thiksey and Hemis

DAY	DESTINATION	SIGNATURE EXPERIENCE
Day 05	**Leh**	A free day: Shanti Stupa, the gompas, the bazaar
Day 06	**Leh to Kargil**	Alchi and Lamayuru on the road west
Day 07	**Kargil to Srinagar**	Over the Zoji La into Kashmir
Day 08	**Srinagar**	A shikara on the lake; optional Pahalgam
Day 09	**Gulmarg**	The meadow of flowers
Day 10	**Srinagar to Delhi**	Fly back to the capital
Day 11	**Delhi**	Departure

Day by Day

Expand all

Day 01 Delhi: Two Cities in One Day

Met on arrival and taken to your hotel, then out into the capital. Raj Ghat first, where Gandhi was cremated; a drive past the Red Fort and Chandni Chowk, and the great courtyard of the Jama Masjid. In the afternoon, Qutub Minar, Humayun's Tomb and India Gate, a drive past Parliament and the presidential estate, and the Lakshminarayan Temple. An early night. Tomorrow's flight is a morning one.

Overnight in Delhi

Day 02 Leh: Arrival at Altitude

Fly · Delhi to Leh, about 90 minutes

The flight into Leh is one of the great approaches in the world, over the Himalaya and down into the Indus valley. Then the important part: nothing. Leh sits at around eleven and a half thousand feet and you have arrived by air, which gives your body no time to adjust, so this day is kept entirely free for acclimatisation. Drink water, walk slowly, sleep. The town and the monasteries will still be there tomorrow, and the travellers who skip this day are the ones who lose the next two.

Overnight in Leh

Day 03 Leh: The Palace and the Nearest Gompas

A gentle day, still at the town's own altitude. The nine-storey Leh Palace of the seventeenth century, modelled on the Potala; the Jama Masjid at the head of the bazaar, with its mix of Tibetan and Islamic form; and the bazaar itself. In the afternoon, two monasteries within easy reach: Spituk, where the Gustor festival unveils a great image of the goddess, and Phyang, with its collection of idols, thangkas and old weaponry.

Overnight in Leh

Day 04 The Indus Monasteries: Shey, Thiksey and Hemis

A full day up the Indus valley. Shey, the old summer palace, with its giant gilded copper Buddha; Thiksey, stacked up its hill like a small Potala, with the fifteen-metre statue of Maitreya, the future Buddha, filling two storeys of its temple; and Hemis, the largest and richest monastery in Ladakh, whose masked festival fills its courtyard every summer. Back to Leh by evening.

Overnight in Leh

Day 05 Leh: A Day as You Wish

A free day, planned as you like. The Shanti Stupa on its hilltop above Changspa, the Sankar and Soma gompas, the war museum, the bazaar, or a short walk out of town on one of the soft trekking routes, now that three nights at altitude have earned it.

Overnight in Leh

Day 06 Alchi and Lamayuru: The Road to Kargil

Drive · Leh to Kargil, about 220 km

West along the Indus. Alchi is the day's great thing: a monastery complex of the eleventh century whose Dukhang, Sumtsek and Manjushri temples hold some of the oldest surviving paintings in Ladakh, in a Kashmiri style that vanished everywhere else. Then Lamayuru, on its moonscape of eroded rock, whose masked festival falls in the second and fifth months of the Tibetan calendar. On to Kargil for the night.

Overnight in Kargil

Day 07 The Zoji La: Into Kashmir

Drive · about 6 hours over the Zoji La

From Kargil to Srinagar over the Zoji La, one of the highest passes on the road and the line where the bare rock of Ladakh gives way to the green of Kashmir. Srinagar is the paradise on earth of the Mughal emperors, who built their gardens here: Chashma Shahi, the Pari Mahal, Nishat Bagh and Shalimar Bagh, with the handicrafts, carpets and shawls the city is known for in the bazaars between.

Overnight in Srinagar

Day 08 Srinagar: A Shikara on the Lake

Boat · Shikara ride on Dal Lake

The morning in a shikara, the slim, canopied boat of the Kashmir lakes, moving through the floating gardens and the daily life that happens on the water. The rest of the day is free in Srinagar, or an optional excursion to Pahalgam, at seven thousand feet in the Lidder valley, from which the Amarnath pilgrimage sets out at Chandanwari.

Overnight in Srinagar

Day 09 Gulmarg: The Meadow of Flowers

A full day at Gulmarg, the meadow of flowers above the Kashmir valley. The gondola climbs towards Apharwat; below it is the highest golf course in the world and, in winter, some of the highest skiing in Asia. In summer the meadow is for walking, riding and doing very little in very good air. Back to Srinagar for the night.

Overnight in Srinagar

Day 10 Delhi: Back to the Plains

Fly · Srinagar to Delhi

Transfer to Srinagar airport for the flight to Delhi, and to your hotel. The rest of the day is free to rest or to go back to whichever part of the city you did not get to on the first day.

Overnight in Delhi

Day 11 Delhi: Departure

Transfer to the airport for your onward flight.

Departure

Practical notes

Best time to visit

June to September. The Leh–Kargil–Srinagar road and the Zoji La are open only in these months; outside them Ladakh is reachable by air but the road out is not.

Altitude

Leh is at about 3,500 metres and you arrive by air. Day two is a full rest day and day three stays at the town's own altitude, and we will not sell this itinerary without them. Anyone with a heart or lung condition should take medical advice first.

Getting there

Pace

Delhi (DEL) is the arrival and departure point; Leh (IXL) and Srinagar (SXR) are both about ninety minutes' flight from it, and both legs are included.	Moderate, and set by the altitude rather than by the schedule: two gentle days at the start, one long road day over the pass, and free time in both Leh and Srinagar.